

Messapic and Albanian: Linguistic Affiliation and the Age of Albanian

Petrit Restelica

13 September 2026

Petrit Restelica is a teacher at Kullagymnasiet in Höganäs, Sweden, and a student at the University of Gothenburg. He writes about the history of Albanian in a personal capacity; neither institution is associated with this review.

Abstract

Messapic is an Indo-European language attested in inscriptions from pre-Roman Apulia. Its possible relationship with the prehistoric ancestor of Albanian remains disputed. Messapic *bilia* and Albanian *bijë*, both meaning ‘daughter’, offer a noteworthy comparison, but the limited corpus does not yet support a secure classification based on regular sound correspondences and shared morphological innovations. This review considers three claims often presented together: that Messapic and Albanian are related, that Messapic was Albanian’s closest ancient relative, and that Messapic can establish the age of Albanian. The first is uncontroversial at the broad Indo-European level; a particularly close relationship is plausible but not established; the third claim does not follow. The earliest surviving Albanian texts are late medieval, whereas the spoken language has a much older prehistory.

Keywords: Messapic; Albanian; historical linguistics; Proto-Albanian; Indo-European; Palaeo-Balkan.

Scope and method

This review compares published assessments of Messapic–Albanian affiliation and examines what they can tell us about chronology. It offers neither new readings of inscriptions nor a quantitative phylogenetic analysis. A resemblance between two words may reflect inheritance from a distant common ancestor, borrowing, or chance. To establish a closer relationship, linguists seek regular sound correspondences and shared innovations. Archaeology and population history can illuminate contact and movement, but neither material objects nor genetic ancestry identify the language someone spoke.

AI-assisted preparation: An OpenAI language model helped locate sources, synthesize arguments, draft the initial text, and prepare the English version. Source descriptions and the claims attributed to Matasović, Hyllested and Joseph, and Marchesini have been checked against their cited texts. The model is not an author. Responsibility for any submitted version rests with its human author.

Arguments for a close relationship

Ranko Matasović regards Messapic *bilia* ‘daughter’ as very probably deriving from the same etymon as Albanian *bijë*. He considers it plausible that Messapic was closely related to the Indo-European dialect ancestral to Albanian, while stressing that little can be said with certainty given the surviving evidence [1]. The comparison deserves

attention, but a single lexical item cannot establish an exclusive Messapic-Albanian branch. Hyllested and Joseph also discuss the relationship of these forms to Latin *filia*: a feature shared more widely within Indo-European cannot automatically be counted as an innovation unique to Messapic and Albanian [2].

Hyllested and Joseph note that Messapic is likely, in a genealogical sense, the closest attested Indo-European language to Albanian. Yet their overall assessment argues for particularly substantial shared innovations between Albanian and Greek, within a broader Palaeo-Balkan context that also includes fragmentarily attested languages such as Messapic [2]. The distinction matters: their observation about Messapic does not amount to a demonstration of an exclusive Messapic-Albanian branch.

Limits of the evidence

Simona Marchesini argues that the available Messapic-Albanian comparisons do not present a sufficient systematic constellation of correspondences in phonology, morphology, and syntax. The large chronological gap between the ancient Messapic inscriptions and the surviving Albanian texts compounds the problem [3]. This does not disprove a close relationship. It does mean that the stronger claim, that Messapic is securely established as Albanian's closest relative, goes beyond what the evidence can demonstrate.

Illyrian cannot simply provide a missing link. The ancient language or languages grouped under that label are too poorly documented in continuous texts to permit the systematic comparison that would establish an identity among Illyrian, Messapic, and Albanian [1, 3].

How old is Albanian?

There is no single date at which a continuously changing language begins. The oldest surviving Albanian sentence is a baptismal formula from 1462, and the first substantial surviving Albanian book dates from 1555 [2]. These are dates for written records, not the beginning of Albanian speech.

The ancestor of Albanian must have been spoken before those texts. Historical reconstruction and layers of older language contact make a substantially earlier linguistic history clear [1, 2, 4]. If the proposed close relationship with Messapic is correct, the relevant common ancestry or shared developments must belong to a period no later than the ancient Messapic attestations. The inscriptions do not reveal when the two lineages diverged [1-3].

Albanian's linguistic prehistory reaches back into antiquity, at least roughly two millennia and likely more. This broad estimate should not be mistaken for an independently measured date for the emergence of modern Albanian or for a date of separation from Messapic. A Messapic inscription is not an Albanian text. Scholars continue to investigate the reconstruction of Proto-Albanian and the relative chronology of its Latin loanwords [4].

Conclusion

The case for a particularly close Messapic-Albanian relationship merits further investigation, but the surviving evidence does not establish Messapic as Albanian's

closest attested relative. More extensive, securely interpreted linguistic material would be needed to test that claim. The date of the earliest surviving Albanian text tells us when the language is first documented, not when it began to be spoken. The Messapic comparison cannot turn that distinction into a precise age for Albanian.

References

1. Matasović, Ranko. A Grammatical Sketch of Albanian for Students of Indo-European, pp. 4–5. <https://mudrac.ffzg.hr/~rmatasov/Albanian>
2. Hyllested, Adam, and Brian D. Joseph. 2022. “Albanian.” In *The Indo-European Language Family: A Phylogenetic Perspective*, 223–245. <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781108758666.013>
3. Marchesini, Simona. 2020. “Messapico.” *Palaeohispanica* 20: 495–530, especially 525–526. <https://ifc.dpz.es/recursos/publicaciones/38/77/14marchesini.pdf>
4. University of Basel. “The Albanian Language in Antiquity,” research project description. <https://daw.philhist.unibas.ch/en/hcl/research/research-projects/snsf-project-the-albanian-language-in-antiquity-en/project/>